

iPhone 16 Pro Max

An iterative upgrade, yet a premium powerhouse

With the iPhone 16 Pro Max, it's clear that Apple is pushing the boundaries of hardware while refining its software experience. Running on iOS 18, the iPhone 16 Pro Max sets the stage for Apple Intelligence, but it feels somewhat unfinished since this feature is not available out of the box. So, does the iPhone 16 Pro Max truly live up to its Pro moniker, or does the absence of AI features diminish its appeal? Let's find out.

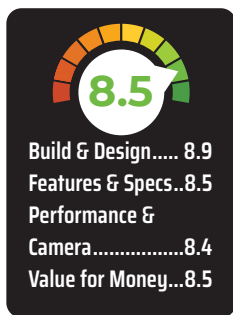
BUILD AND DESIGN

Apple continues its legacy of premium design with the iPhone 16 Pro Max. The aerospace-grade titanium frame is lightweight, yet the device feels both durable and substantial in hand. While the flat-edged design retains the signature iPhone look, slightly rounded corners enhance comfort for extended use.

Apple's meticulous attention to detail shines through in every aspect of the phone's build. The back features frosted glass that resists fingerprints more effectively than the glossy finishes of previous models. Additionally, the phone boasts an IP68 rating for water and dust resistance, offering users peace of mind regarding its durability.

Equipped with the 2024 version of Ceramic Shield protection, Apple claims this is the toughest glass on the market. However, in my experience, it scratches more easily than Gorilla Glass Victus 2 or Armor. On the audio front, the iPhone 16 Pro Max now features studio-grade microphones that deliver sublime sound. They are loud and powerful enough to enhance phone calls and media playback. One minor drawback is the sheer size of the device. The 6.9-inch display makes the iPhone 16 Pro Max a two-handed

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phone for many users. While the lighter titanium frame helps, it remains bulky, which may be cumbersome for some to carry.

This year, Apple has introduced an additional button: Camera Control, located on the right side of the frame. However, this feature didn't impress me. It's too fiddly, especially in portrait mode, and the force required to press it can lead to shaky, blurry images. Surprisingly, this feels more like a gimmick than a functional enhancement from Apple.

DISPLAY

The display on the iPhone 16 Pro Max is nothing short of stunning. Apple has further trimmed the bezels this year, resulting in an immersive viewing experience that is truly impressive. My only hope is that Apple can reduce the pill-shaped Dynamic Island cutout even more next year to enhance that immersion even further.

With a ProMotion 120Hz refresh rate and a peak brightness of 2,000 nits, the iPhone 16 Pro Max boasts one of the brightest and most fluid displays on the market. Whether you're scrolling through apps, watching HDR or Dolby Vision content, or playing games, everything appears incredibly smooth and vibrant. Apple has refined its OLED panels to perfection; colors pop with remarkable accuracy, while blacks are deep and inky, providing excellent contrast.

While the brightness levels are outstanding, the Pixel 9 Pro XL does have the edge when it comes to brightness under direct sunlight. I measured a maximum brightness of 1,662 nits on a sunny day—though not the highest reading we've encountered, it still ranks among the best.

A standout feature of the display is the Always-On Display, which now integrates more seamlessly with widgets and notifications. However, I did notice some battery drain with the Always-On Display activated, particularly when on standby. Thankfully, the display can dial back its refresh rate to as low as 1 Hz, which helps conserve battery life.

PERFORMANCE

After hours of testing, it's clear that the A18 Pro chip in the iPhone 16 Pro Max is a powerhouse. Performance is silky smooth across the board, with tasks handled effortlessly. Whether it's gaming, multitasking, or demanding applications like on-the-go video editing, this chip excels. App-switching is fluid, and apps open in an instant, making it a joy to use, especially for power users who demand seamless performance.

In the 3DMark Wild Life Extreme Stress Test, the phone scored a solid 74.40% in stability, which is commendable. However, while the first loop was impressive, the second loop saw some performance throttling, after which things leveled off. The phone's surface temperature hit 39.1°C during this test, which is quite high. I also noticed some heating during simple tasks like taking photos, and it was more noticeable compared to the iPhone 15 Pro Max. That said, everyday gaming is still smooth. BGMI